

MAINTAINING JOY IN DIFFICULT CIRCUMSTANCES

TEXT: Philippians 4:4-8 (NKJV) *“Rejoice in the Lord always. Again I will say, rejoice!”⁵ Let your gentleness be known to all men. The Lord is at hand.⁶ Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God; ⁷ and the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus.*

⁸ Finally, brethren, whatever things are true, whatever things are noble, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report, if there is any virtue and if there is anything praiseworthy—meditate on these things. ⁹ The things which you learned and received and heard and saw in me, these do, and the God of peace will be with you.” 1 Peter 1:13 *“Wherefore gird up the loins of your mind, be sober, and hope to the end for*

the grace that is to be brought unto you at the revelation of Jesus Christ.”

INTRO: As we begin the month of November we are moving very rapidly toward the end of the calendar year and into a time of several major holidays in rapid succession:

- Thanksgiving...
- Christmas... (Susan’s love for Christmas – Got in trouble with the HOA for putting our Christmas lights up at the beginning of October – Jason say’s it looks like Christmas threw up on our house)
- New Years...

While this should be the “*Most wonderful time of the year*” for many it will be a time when they will struggle with depression. (I am dreading thanksgiving because this will be the first Thanksgiving without my mom)

As we speed toward these holidays I felt particularly drawn to preach on how to maintain

joy despite the circumstances. For some of you, this series of messages is going to be a lifeline in a sea of depression. For others, the struggle you are in, has nothing to do with the holidays, but the battle you are in, is no less real.

Throughout this series of messages, I am going to give you some principles, that if followed, will give you the ability to maintain joy in difficult circumstances, not only now, but in the future.

In the Twenty Sixth chapter of the book of Acts we find the Apostle Paul standing before Agrippa about to answer questions concerning his behavior within the religious community. He had been accused of all kinds of blasphemous acts when in reality there was absolutely no evidence to support the charges. In a very short period of time Paul had gone from being a rising star, to being a shooting star, In religious politics, that's not as hard to do as you might think!

In this passage, Paul had been arrested and tried by the religious authorities of his day, and because no one could find anything within his character worthy of prison or death, they passed him around like a political hot potato, hoping someone would be devious enough to convict him without evidence.

Everyone in jail and prison declares themselves to be innocent, when the evidence points to their guilt. Yet, there are circumstances where people are wrongly convicted, incarcerated, and sometimes executed. We are absolutely taken back by such things.

This kind of thing happens in religious circles far more often than it happens in the world. The church is the only army in the world that kills its wounded. In church politics, you don't have to be guilty – If you are accused - You are guilty until you prove yourself innocent, beyond all doubt.

Paul was an innocent prisoner who was about to lose his life because he had crossed the wrong people within the religious system.

While Paul was in Ephesus for his final time he spoke of his incarceration in this manner: Acts 20:22-23 ***“And now, behold, I go bound in the spirit unto Jerusalem, not knowing the things that shall befall me there: 23 Save that the Holy Ghost witnesseth in every city, saying that bonds and afflictions abide me.”***

Paul had every opportunity to become angry, and develop a sour disposition and attitude. (Have you ever known anyone with a sour disposition and attitude? Don't say amen or look around) 2 Corinthians 11:23-28 ***“... I have worked much harder, been in prison more frequently, been flogged more severely, and been exposed to death again and again. 24 Five times I received from the Jews the forty lashes minus one. 25 Three times I was beaten with rods, once I was stoned, three times I was***

shipwrecked, I spent a night and a day in the open sea, 26 I have been constantly on the move. I have been in danger from rivers, in danger from bandits, in danger from my own countrymen, in danger from Gentiles; in danger in the city, in danger in the country, in danger at sea; and in danger from false brothers. 27 I have labored and toiled and have often gone without sleep; I have known hunger and thirst and have often gone without food; I have been cold and naked. 28 Besides everything else, I face daily the pressure of my concern for all the churches.”

Would these problems be enough to cause us to be discouraged or quit? Would they make us lose our joy or become unhappy? All of us must admit that we have had the sweet licked off of our candy by far less!

We must stop allowing our disposition to sour, and our attitudes to become bad, because of the circumstances we find ourselves in. *“The joy of*

the Lord is our strength.” We need to man up and woman up and maintain joy in difficult times.

Listen to what Paul had to say about maintaining joy in difficult circumstances. Acts 20:24 ***“But none of these things move me, neither count I my life dear unto myself, so that I might finish my course with joy, and the ministry, which I have received of the Lord Jesus, to testify the gospel of the grace of God.”***

How could Paul possibly maintain an attitude of victory in such a turbulent time in his life? I believe he lets us in on the secret to his attitude of victory, even though he knew he was staring death in the whites of the eyes. Listen to the first four words he says to Agrippa, Acts 26:2 ***“I think myself happy...”*** I am aware that Paul was saying to Agrippa that he was happy for the opportunity to finally tell his side of the story. However, I believe these four words, ***“I think***

myself happy,” characterize the life and ministry of the Apostle Paul.

He had served and ministered in places where he had to figure out how to maintain joy in difficult circumstances. Otherwise he could not have continued on. If we do not figure out how to do the same – We cannot continue on! The devil will surely steal our joy and drive us into a pit of depression.

Paul practiced the art of maintaining joy in difficult circumstances to the point that he was able to say, Philip. 4:11 “... ***I have learned, in whatsoever state I am, therewith to be content.***” The ability to maintain joy and contentment in difficult circumstances is a level of Christian maturity that most people never attain. There is no such thing as happiness without contentment:

- To be filled with joy, we must be content...
- To be content, we must be relaxed... (Have you ever known anyone who was as calm as

a cucumber while all hell was breaking out in their life? – My dad is that kind of guy – Roy Hansen)

- To be relaxed we must be comfortable with the circumstances of our lives...
- To be comfortable with our circumstances, we must believe we are in the will of God...

No matter what the place or the circumstances look like that surround us:

- The safest place on earth is the will of God...
- The place of greatest supply is the will of God...
- The place of greatest joy on earth, is the will of God...

Given the circumstances of his life, how could Paul maintain joy in such difficult times? He let us in on this secret three verses earlier.

Philippians 4:8 ***“Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is noble, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever***

is admirable--if anything is excellent or praiseworthy--think about such things.”

Please understand, this is not mind over matter, this is about girding up the loins of our minds, and controlling our thought lives, so that the joy of the Lord can strengthen us! ***“I reckon the suffering of this present time shall not be worthy of the glory that shall be revealed in us.”*** (USE A BALANCE TO ILLUSTRATE THIS)

It is possible, even in difficult circumstances, to maintain a level of joy that confuses the enemy and causes others to question why we are so happy. ***“The joy of the Lord is my strength.”***

(END OF SERMON ONE)

Philippians 4:4-8 (NKJV) ***“Rejoice in the Lord always. Again I will say, rejoice!⁵ Let your gentleness be known to all men. The Lord is at hand.⁶ Be anxious for nothing, but in***

everything by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God; ⁷ and the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus.

⁸ Finally, brethren, whatever things are true, whatever things are noble, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report, if there is any virtue and if there is anything praiseworthy—meditate on these things. ⁹ The things which you learned and received and heard and saw in me, these do, and the God of peace will be with you.” 1 Peter 1:13 “Wherefore gird up the loins of your mind, be sober, and hope to the end for the grace that is to be brought unto you at the revelation of Jesus Christ.”

Last week:

- Developing a proper attitude...

The Apostle Peter gives a three-point outline on how to maintain joy in difficult circumstances.

According to the Apostle Peter there are three things we must do in order to maintain joy despite the circumstances:

I. GIRD UP THE LOINS OF YOUR MIND

II. BE SOBER

III. HOPE TO THE END

I. GIRD UP THE LOINS OF YOUR MIND

The word “***gird***” as it is used here, comes from the Greek word “*anazonnumi*” (anna -zone’-noo-mee). This word comes from two Greek words – “*ana*” (anna) which means “*to prop up by repetition*” and “*zonnumi*” (zone’-noo-mi) meaning “*to bind about as with a belt.*” The Apostle Peter is saying that the person who wins the battlefield of the mind will win the war.

Unless we learn to control our thought life, we have no chance of maintaining joy in difficult circumstances.

Always remember, the battle will not be fought with boxing gloves or fisty-cuffs, the real battle will be fought between our ears. It is here that the battle will be won or lost! Romans 8:5-9

“For they that are after the flesh do mind the things of the flesh; but they that are after the Spirit the things of the Spirit. 6 For to be carnally minded is death; but to be spiritually minded is life and peace. 7 Because the carnal mind is enmity against God: for it is not subject to the law of God, neither indeed can be. 8 So then they that are in the flesh cannot please God. 9 But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit, if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you. Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his.” The Apostle is saying that it is up to us to control our own thought life.

God is not going to control our thoughts and imaginations, it is our responsibility to set a guard at the door of our mind. My mother used to say, *“Don, you can’t keep a bird from flying over your head, but you can keep him from building a nest in your hair.”*

We must learn to gird up the loins of our mind by controlling what we allow ourselves to think about. Our thoughts will provoke the joy of the Lord in our lives, or they will provoke heaviness and depression. They will provoke us to righteousness or to sinful behaviors and patterns. Philippians 2:5 ***“Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ Jesus.”*** “Let” suggests that we must be in control of what we allow in and out of our lives. We are to bind good thoughts to our minds and release evil thoughts from our minds. (Illustrate this by cinching and releasing a belt around something)

Philippians 4:7-8 ***“And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your***

hearts and minds through Christ Jesus. (Talk about this – The peace of God supersedes – Trumps – every problem we encounter) 8
Finally, brethren, whatsoever things are true, whatsoever things are honest, whatsoever things are just, whatsoever things are pure, whatsoever things are lovely, whatsoever things are of good report; if there be any virtue, and if there be any praise, think on these things.”

If we are going to maintain joy in difficult circumstances we must learn to *“Put on the garment of praise for the spirit of heaviness...”*

The only way we will ever be able to maintain joy in difficult circumstances is by controlling our mind through repetition. The patterns of thought that have been worn into our brains are of our own doing. Are we going to think on good things or evil things? If we spend most of our time reflecting on the goodness of God, we will without question be able to maintain joy in

difficult circumstances. Defeat or victory is decided by the way we have trained ourselves to think!

If we allow our minds to dwell of what could have been, what should have been, or what might have been, we will not have a snowballs chance in Houston of maintaining joy in difficult circumstances.

That's why it is so important to sing songs like:
“Think about his love, think about his goodness, think about his grace, that's brought us through. For as high as the heavens above, so great is the measure of our Father's love. So great is the measure of our Father's love.”

“When I think about his goodness and what he's done for me, I think about his goodness and how he's set me free... makes me praise... dance... jump... run... shout... all night.”

“Look what the Lord has done. Look what the Lord has done. He healed my body, He touched my mind, He saved me just in time. I’m gonna praise his name, each day he’s just the same, come on and praise him, look what the Lord has done.”

When writing to his choir director, David said, Psalm 39:1-3 ***“I will take heed to my ways, that I sin not with my tongue: I will keep my mouth with a bridle, while the wicked is before me. 2 I was dumb with silence, I held my peace, even from good; and my sorrow was stirred. 3 My heart was hot within me, while I was musing the fire burned...”***

David didn’t just write about meditating on the works of God’s hands. He meditated on the acts and deeds of God until he actually practiced thinking himself happy! Psalm 143:1-5 ***“Hear my prayer, O Lord, give ear to my supplications: in thy faithfulness answer me, and in thy righteousness. 2 And enter not into***

judgment with thy servant: for in thy sight shall no man living be justified. 3 For the enemy hath persecuted my soul; he hath smitten my life down to the ground; he hath made me to dwell in darkness, as those that have been long dead. 4 Therefore is my spirit overwhelmed within me; my heart within me is desolate. 5 I remember the days of old; I meditate on all thy works; I muse on the work of thy hands.”

Chapter 143 was mostly negative but notice how chapter 144 begins Psalm 144:1-2 *“Blessed be the Lord my strength, which teacheth my hands to war, and my fingers to fight: 2 My goodness, and my fortress; my high tower, and my deliverer; my shield, and he in whom I trust; who subdueth my people under me.”*

On several occasions, the Bible says that David, *“Encouraged himself in the Lord.”* I’m about to preach myself happy. Someone in here needs to encourage themselves in the Lord.

Through controlling what he allowed his mind to think about, David actually thought himself happy rather than thinking himself sad! You and I can do the same!

We will either do what is necessary to maintain joy in difficult circumstances or we will find ourselves hopelessly trapped in a vicious cycle of depression and heaviness. The decision is ours. Are we going to be defeated or will we remain joyful despite difficult circumstances?

(END OF SERMON TWO)

II. BE SOBER

Philippians 4:4-8 (NKJV) *“Rejoice in the Lord always. Again I will say, rejoice!”⁵ Let your gentleness be known to all men. The Lord is at hand.⁶ Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God; ⁷ and the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your*

hearts and minds through Christ Jesus.

⁸ Finally, brethren, whatever things are true, whatever things are noble, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report, if there is any virtue and if there is anything praiseworthy—meditate on these things. ⁹ The things which you learned and received and heard and saw in me, these do, and the God of peace will be with you.” 1 Peter 1:13 “Wherefore gird up the loins of your mind, be sober, and hope to the end for the grace that is to be brought unto you at the revelation of Jesus Christ.”

The last two weeks:

- Develop a proper attitude...
- Gird up the loins of our minds...

The word “**sober**” comes from the Greek word “*nepho* (nay’-fo), and means “*to abstain from wine. Be alert!*”

The Apostle Peter say's four chapters later, 1 Peter 5:8 ***“Be sober, be vigilant; because your adversary the devil, as a roaring lion, walketh about, seeking whom he may devour.”***

There is a major difference between the word ***“may”*** and the word ***“can”***. The word ***“may”*** denotes that he must get permission. The word ***“can”*** denotes he is able and does not need permission! I am here to inform you that while the devil ***“may”*** defeat us, it is not a foregone conclusion. I rise to remind us today that he ***“cannot”*** unless we give him permission to do so!

Peter is saying that our ability to remain ***“sober”*** will directly affect our ability to win battles, and maintain joy in difficult circumstances. (Song: This is how I fight my battles)

You may be thinking, ***“how could sobriety affect my ability to maintain joy in difficult circumstances?”***

Sobriety is not the ability to frown or maintain a gruff exterior nor the denial of circumstances in a quest for happiness. The sobriety that Peter was speaking of is a sane estimation of the circumstances that surround our lives, coupled with a faith that God is bigger than the problem!

When we begin to look at our circumstances through God's looking glasses, it won't take us long to understand that we can maintain joy, despite the difficult circumstances. If we cannot see a thing, we must give up, or get a more powerful magnifier. (My vision when I was finishing up the book, *The Audacity of Prayer* – I had to use a magnifying glass)

What is in our magnifier?

- Our problems?
- Our difficulty?
- Our failures?
- Our all sufficient, omnipotent, omnipresent, omniscient God?

Our joy is not determined by the circumstances, it is determined by what we are focused on!

If we are intoxicated by this world, and what it has to offer, our circumstances will never be good enough to make us truly happy. In fact, our circumstances will get the best of us!

Look at the Children of Israel. The spies went into Canaan to look the land over. Caleb and Joshua came back believing they were able to conquer the land. They said ***“Let us go up at once, for we are well able to take the land.”***

But notice the report of the other ten goobers. Numbers 13:31-33 ***“But the men that went up with him said, We be not able to go up against the people; for they are stronger than we. 32 And they brought up an evil report of the land which they had searched unto the children of Israel, saying, The land, through which we have gone to search it, is a land that eateth up***

the inhabitants thereof; and all the people that we saw in it are men of a great stature. 33 And there we saw the giants, the sons of Anak, which come of the giants: and we were in our own sight as grasshoppers, and so we were in their sight.” These dipsticks didn’t just shut themselves out, they kept everyone else out. *“They made the hearts of the people melt.”*

They were:

- Wet blankets...
- Joy drainers...
- Dream killers...
- Faith exterminators...
- Stick-in-the-muds...

Caleb and Joshua were focused on the fact that the land was everything God had said it would be, therefore they believed the Lord would deliver it into their hands! (The ten spies focused on the giants – Caleb & Joshua focused on the fruit – Once they actually got into Canaan no one even fought a giant for 150 years)

The problem with these ten spies? They were still intoxicated by Egypt - They were still operating under a slave mentality – They believed nothing good would ever happen for them - They were negative Nancy's.

Consequently, Caleb and Joshua were the only two from their generation allowed to possess the land! Why? They maintained a good attitude of joy – despite the difficult circumstances.

Are we going to live in the wilderness of doubt and unbelief, or are we going to express faith and confidence in God, and maintain a victorious attitude – despite the difficult circumstances?

When we begin to sober up from the intoxication of this world, and see it the way God sees it, we will have great joy – despite the difficulties we face. The reason our disposition will change is that we stop seeing the enormity

of the battle and begin to see the vastness of the victory.

In first-grade we all read a book about a little train that was carrying a very heavy load. This little train was approaching a hill that seemed too steep to climb. As the little train approached the hill he could be heard to say “*I think I can. I think I can. I think I can. I t-h-i-n-k I c-a-n. I t--h--i--n--k-- I c--a--n. I t---h---i---n---k I c---a---n.*”

This little train did not deny the circumstances. He knew the hill was steep, and the load was heavy. What the little train knew, that bystanders were not aware of, was the power of his momentum, and the size of the engine in his locomotive would be sufficient to outlast the uphill climb.

When the little train topped the hill and began his descent, he could be heard saying, “*I thought I could. I thought I could. I thought I*

could.” The little train thought himself happy and we can do the same!

We will either think ourselves happy or think ourselves sad, the decision is ours!

(END OF SERMON THREE)

III. HOPE TO THE END

Philippians 4:4-8 (NKJV) *“Rejoice in the Lord always. Again I will say, rejoice!”⁵ Let your gentleness be known to all men. The Lord is at hand.⁶ Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God; ⁷ and the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus.*

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loins of your mind, be sober, and hope to the
end for the grace that is to be brought unto you
at the revelation of Jesus Christ.”*

Last three weeks:

- Developing a proper attitude...
- Gird up the loins of our minds...
- Be sober...

This week I want to talk about “*Hoping to the end.*” The NIV puts it like this: 1 Peter 1:13
“*Therefore, prepare your minds for action; be self-controlled; set your hope fully on the grace to be given you when Jesus Christ is revealed.*”

The word “**hope**,” as it is used here, comes from the Greek word “*elpizo*” (el-pid’zo), and means “*to expect or trust.*”

The word “**end**,” as it is used here, comes from the Greek word “*teleioz*” (tel-i’-oce), and means “*without wavering to completion.*”

Hope is an indispensable element in the lives of those who are determined to maintain joy – despite difficult circumstances.

I want you to know that William Jefferson Clinton is not the only person that still believes in a place called hope! (NIV) Hebrews 6:16-19
“Men swear by someone greater than themselves, and the oath confirms what is said and puts an end to all argument. 17 Because God wanted to make the unchanging nature of his purpose very clear to the heirs of what was promised, he confirmed it with an oath. 18 God did this so that, by two unchangeable things in which it is impossible for God to lie, we who

have fled to take hold of the hope offered to us may be greatly encouraged. 19 We have this hope as an anchor for the soul, firm and secure. It enters the inner sanctuary behind the curtain,”

Notice this:

- This is not just any hope... It is **“This Hope”** - *“My hope is built on nothing less, than Jesus Christ, my righteousness; I dare not trust the sweetest frame, but wholly lean on Jesus name. On Christ the solid rock I stand, all other ground is sinking sand. All other ground is sinking sand. When darkness veils His lovely face, I rest in His unchanging grace; In every high and stormy gale, my anchor holds within the veil. On Christ the solid rock I stand, all other ground is sinking sand. All other ground is sinking sand. When He shall come with trumpet sound, oh may I then in Him be found; In Him my righteousness alone, faultless stand before His throne. On Christ*

the solid rock I stand, all other ground is sinking sand. All other ground is sinking sand.”

- This hope enters into His presence...
- This hope is connected to that which is behind the curtain... (God lives there)

1 Peter 1:13 ***“Therefore, prepare your minds for action; be self-controlled; set your hope fully on the grace to be given you when Jesus Christ is revealed.”*** Notice three things from this passage:

- Prepare your mind for action...
- Practice self-controlled behavior...
- Set your hope on the provision of God...

In a nutshell, the Apostle Peter is saying that if we get focused on the end of the race all the setbacks along the journey will have little to no effect on us.

When building a house, the frame goes up quick and it's not too difficult to keep the morale up

during this stage of construction. However, once this stage is complete things slow down and some day's it seems as though nothing at all is being accomplished. It is during these times that one must keep the final product in focus. The builder must focus on giving the keys to the home owner and collecting final payment. The homeowner must stay focused on the house warming party.

This is true of the Christian life. There is no question, we will meet with discouraging times and circumstances but we must never fail to ***“Hope to the end.”***

The writer of Hebrews gives us a little snapshot into what allowed Jesus to maintain an attitude of Joy, despite the fact that he knew what awaited him at the cross! (NIV) Hebrews 12:2 ***“Let us fix our eyes on Jesus, the author and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy set before him endured the cross, scorning its***

shame, and sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.” Jesus forced Himself to:

- Live beyond the betrayal of friends, family and disciples...
- Look beyond the pain of Pilates Judgement Hall...
- Peer past the agony of the brutal beating at the hands of demon possessed Roman soldiers...
- Fix His gaze beyond Golgotha to a loving Heavenly Father who would raise Him from the dead...
- Focus on the fact that Satan overplayed his hand and would suffer his greatest defeat in the halls of hell, as soon as the stone was rolled in front of the door of a dark tomb...
- Not consider the discouraging appearance of a dark tomb on the outskirts of Jerusalem, because He knew that three days later - the tables would turn and death and hell would finally be defeated, once and for all..

“For the joy that was set before Him...” Can someone in here ***“Hope to the end of your trouble?”***

Jesus lived his life in anticipation of:

- The day the grave would burst open...
- The day he would be able to walk through walls again...
- The day he would stand at Bethany’s launching pad and gravity would lose its power over his body...
- The day he would be seated at the Father’s right hand...
- The day His role would shift from savior to intercessor...

Because of this, it didn’t matter how bad the circumstances were, he was able to remain joyful in difficult circumstances. Can we do the same?

If we are going to maintain joy in difficult circumstances, we must develop a vision that is

capable of leap-frogging our present circumstances!

Some people say I'm doing pretty well under the circumstances. Who gave you permission to get under the circumstances? God's word says that ***"...the God of peace shall bruise satan under your feet shortly"***.

How can we have the kind of hope that allows us to focus on the end result? Paul said to the Roman church - Romans 15:4 ***"For whatsoever things were written aforetime were written for our learning, that we through patience and comfort of the scriptures might have hope."***

- Patience... Hebrews 10:35-36 ***"Cast not away therefore your confidence, which hath great recompence of reward. 36 For ye have need of patience, that, after ye have done the will of God, ye might receive the promise."***
- The Word of God... Pentecostal people are notorious for wanting to live on a fuzzy

feeling. I like to shout and praise the Lord as much as the next person but we cannot afford to base our joy on our feelings – Our joy is derived from what the Word of God has to say on the matter! The highest form of reality is not what the facts indicate, but what the Word say's. The Word of God say's we are redeemed! That we are accepted! That we are victorious! That we will be glorified! That despite our suffering here, we will reign with our Lord!

- Keeping our focus on the end result... 1 John 3:1-3 ***“Behold, what manner of love the Father hath bestowed upon us, that we should be called the sons of God: therefore the world knoweth us not, because it knew him not. 2 Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is. 3 And every man that hath this hope in him purifieth himself, even as he is pure.”***

CONCLUSION:

We are to maintain joy in difficult circumstances by hoping for:

- Rev. 22:12 *“And, behold, I come quickly; and my reward is with me, to give every man according as his work shall be.”*
- Romans 8:18 *“For I reckon that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory which shall be revealed in us.”*
- 1 Corinthians 15:51-58 *“Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, 52 In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed. 53 For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality. 54 So when this corruptible shall have put on incorruption, and this mortal shall have put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass*

the saying that is written, Death is swallowed up in victory. 55 O death, where is thy sting? O grave, where is thy victory? 56 The sting of death is sin; and the strength of sin is the law. 57 But thanks be to God, which giveth us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ. 58 Therefore, my beloved brethren, be ye stedfast, unmovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, forasmuch as ye know that your labour is not in vain in the Lord.”

- *1 Thes. 4:13-18 “But I would not have you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning them which are asleep, that ye sorrow not, even as others which have no hope. 14 For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so them also which sleep in Jesus will God bring with him. 15 For this we say unto you by the word of the Lord, that we which are alive and remain unto the coming of the Lord shall not prevent them which are asleep. 16 For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the*

voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first: 17 Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord. 18 Wherefore comfort one another with these words.”